CHILD'S PLAY

A Play, by Alyssa Zaczek

Copyright 2013 Alyssa Zacsek.
Free performance of this play for high school
and college level competitive forensics is permitted.
All other rights reserved.

The Intriguing Interp Series
is published by
Mushroom Cloud Press
A Division of Big Rodent Prouctions, Brooklyn, NY

For more information and performance rights, contact
BIG RODENT PRODUCTIONS
146 SUMMIT ST. #3
Brooklyn, NY 11231
joe@mushroomcloudpress.com
http://www.mushroomcloudpress.com/

ISSN listed in graphic seal below.



ATTENTION FORENSICS COMPETITION GOVERNING BODIES: IF YOU THINK THIS SCRIPT HAS BEEN ILLEGALLY COPIED, CONTACT MUSHROOMCLOUDPRESS@GMAIL.COM TO VERIFY.

Child's Play

By Alyssa Zaczek

SCENE I

At center, RYAN, a charming yet awkward Jason Bateman-type, speaks to the audience.

RYAN: My life is filled with routine. I don't mind it, actually, I'm a man of simple means. I like toys. I love the nostalgia of things from your childhood, you know? GI Joes and trains with whistles and Rock'em Sock'em Robots. They're comforting. So every morning I get up, I cook breakfast, and I go to work. At a toy store. It's been the same for years and years, until she showed up. You would think I'd recognize trouble in high heels when it walks right towards you and introduces itself, but it's been so long without trouble for me, I guess it took me a while.

The scene shifts into Ryan at the toy shop, struggling with a remote control, trying to get a helicopter off the ground. JESSICA, sultry and captivating, watches, unbeknownst to him. After a few attempts to get the helicopter moving, Jessica speaks:

JESSICA: Still playing with toy helicopters, huh? Some things never change.

Ryan, flustered, drops the remote control and turns in a hurry.

RYAN: Jesus, I'm sorry, ma'am, I didn't see you there. *(With obligation; this is the usual spiel:)* Welcome to Toy Tantrum: Our Toy Selection is Cr-azy! How may I help you?

JESSICA: *(After a beat)* You don't recognize me?

RYAN: I'm sorry?

JESSICA: You don't recognize me.

RYAN: What-

JESSICA: Gangly little Ryan Richards, still playing with toys after all these years.

She smiles in disbelief as a look of comprehension washes over Ryan.

RYAN: Wait . . .

JESSICA: *(Singing) Oh, Camp Kickapoo, we'll spend a week at-you, and cook a s'more or two, in the summer sun!*

RYAN: Jessica? Jessica Monroe?

JESSICA: Good to see you again, Ryan.

RYAN: Oh my god. Wow. The last time I saw you-

JESSICA: We were seventeen?

RYAN: Yeah. Yeah. Wow.

JESSICA: So this must be your toy store, then! The one you talked my ear off about opening. Good for you!

RYAN: Uh, no, not exactly.

JESSICA: Oh?

RYAN: My wife and I are trying to save up for me to open a store of my own, but for now I just work here. I'm a manager.

JESSICA: *(Taken aback)* Your wife?

RYAN: Nancy.

JESSICA: Nancy Lewis? That know-it-all math freak from camp? *(Ryan grimaces; she realizes what she's said)* Sorry.

RYAN: Yeah, that's her. She's Nancy Richards now. *(An awkward beat)* So, what brings you back home? Last I heard you were some hot-shot advertising executive in the city.

JESSICA: Ah yes, my fame and fortune in the city. Well, that came to a grinding halt last week when I got fired. *(Laughs)* Thirty years old and getting canned like I'm a teenager working at a pizza stand all over again. So I had to move back home. Can't afford the hot-shot apartment and the hot-shot life anymore.

RYAN: Oh. Jes, I'm sorry.

JESSICA: That's alright. But it brings me to my next question: are you hiring?

SCENE II

The scene shifts to Ryan and Jessica sitting at a table in the Toy Tantrum break room. It is after hours. They drink coffee, and our first sight of them is a burst of laughter, having been in conversation.

RYAN: So that was your first day in toy retail, huh?

JESSICA: Needless to say I know nothing about children's toys. Or children! I don't know why you even hired me.

RYAN: Hey, anything to help a friend.

JESSICA: Well, thanks. It was good of you. I'm surprised you don't have a store of your own by now, really. I don't mean anything by that, it's just . . . you were always so passionate about the toys of your childhood, you know? All those stories you told me about your father playing Lincoln Logs with you before he died; they were sweet. I really thought . . . I don't know, I really thought you would make it.

RYAN: We're working on it. It's been hard-

JESSICA: Supporting the kids?

RYAN: What? Oh, no, we don't have any kids.

JESSICA: Why not?

RYAN: Nancy never wanted them. Too focused on her work. Accounting, you know, it's sort of taxing. No pun intended.

JESSICA: That sucks.

RYAN: What?

JESSICA: Ryan, come on.

RYAN: Come on, what?

JESSICA: You've always wanted kids! Even at seventeen years old you couldn't shut up for a week about all the stuff you wanted to do with your kids when you were a dad! You want to open a toy store, for Christ's sake, like some sort of new-age Willy Wonka! You were born to be a dad!

RYAN: I don't know about that. . . Nancy was just always more work-oriented. And I loved that about her-

JESSICA: Loved? Past-tense?

RYAN: *(After a beat)* Look, if you must know, things haven't been great lately, that's all I'm going to say.

JESSICA: Well. *(There is a pause, as Jessica takes a sip of her coffee. Ryan watches her.)* What are you looking at?

RYAN: Remember that night at camp, when we snuck out of our cabins and went down to the lake? And it was getting colder at night by then but you still insisted that we try to get into the water? So we stripped down to our underwear, and I watched you the whole time, by the way, and when we waded in up to our chests we were shivering and blue. And you felt something brush against your leg – a fish or a piece of seaweed or something – and you *screamed,* like your

family had been axe-murdered, and jumped against my chest with that splash – Jesus, I thought you were going to wake every counselor on the place. But instead you just looked at me, and you started to laugh, like it was the funniest thing in the world, like you were a movie star, and you-

JESSICA: Kissed you. *(Looking up from her coffee, smiling)* I kissed you.

RYAN: And it was the most amazing first kiss I've ever had, I think. Even if my lips were blue and my teeth were chattering and I smelled like lake water and seaweed. *(A beat)* I don't know, it's just nice, remembering.

Jessica stares at Ryan for a beat as he smiles into his coffee cup. Finally:

JESSICA: Are you stupid?

RYAN: What?

JESSICA: Do you honestly think that I came back home just to work retail in a kids' toy shop? I could have gotten a crappy apartment and a mile's worth of chain restaurants and shopping malls anywhere, Ryan, did you really think I had no other reason for coming back home?

RYAN: I . . . I thought maybe you missed your family, your old house . . . ?

JESSICA: Of course not!

RYAN: Okay, so what?

JESSICA: I remember the night we kissed. I remember it clear as day. It's almost fifteen years later and I can still remember how our teeth clicked against each other's before we found our rhythm in that kiss, that perfect kiss. Do you remember what happened next?

RYAN: Jessica . . .

JESSICA: We were inseparable. We wrote each other letter at night to give to each other in the mornings. We snuck out to kiss in the woods behind the cabins and we held hands at the campfires. We talked about what we'd be doing at twenty, at twenty five, at thirty. We fell in love.

RYAN: Jes, please-

JESSICA: Didn't we?

RYAN: *(Hesitantly)* Yes.

JESSICA: And almost fifteen years later, part of me feels like I missed out on a huge . . . something. Like a chunk of my life is missing because I didn't call you after camp. You know,

life happened, and we both got busy with our own things, but . . . doesn't part of you wonder if you were supposed to end up with your first true love?

RYAN: I'm married, Jessica.

JESSICA: Yes, and you haven't said a single good word about your marriage yet! But you can sit in front of me and reminisce about the good old days, about a romance that happened so long ago? About watching me undress in the moonlight? That's not a healthy marriage, Ryan, that's denial!

RYAN: And what is it you came here expecting me to do? Leave my wife? Get a divorce and run away with you?

Jessica stands, and leans against the table, looking down at Ryan. She is a vision in sex-appeal.

JESSICA: Haven't you thought about it? Every once and a while? What would have happened back then, had we ever gotten a place to really have privacy? If maybe I wouldn't have been just your first love, but your first-

RYAN: You didn't call me. You told me you'd call and you never did. I tried to call you but your parents always told me you were out. It's been over a decade, and you expect me to fall to my knees in longing for you? What world are you living in?

JESSICA: I'm living in the world where I never stopped loving you! *(A beat)* I have no excuse for not calling you. I was . . . afraid, of how much I loved you, after so short a time. And I know that's the worst excuse in the book, I know. But we used to lay out on the grass and talked about our futures; about a life together. We did! I know you're going to try not to remember it now, but we wanted this.

RYAN: Well, I grew up. Those were children's fantasies.

JESSICA: We were old enough to know what love felt like! And don't act like you're so mature now; which one of us has spent their entire adult life working a dead end job at a toy store and which one of us moved on?

RYAN: *(Exploding)* I don't know, Jes! You tell me! Because you're the one holding onto a relationship that barely happened, fifteen years ago! You're the one that never got over a fling at summer camp! I've had a life since then! A job, a wife, a mortgage! What do you have? What do you have?

A beat. Jessica has recoiled; Ryan is now standing up out of his chair in anger.

JESSICA: I don't have much, Ryan, and I know you think I'm out of my damn mind, but I have love for you. I have thought about you so often. And maybe your wife loves you too, I don't know. But I think she loves her job more than she's ever loved you, the real you. I remember the

Ryan who, at seventeen years old, had a budgeted plan for becoming an entrepreneur after college. I remember the Ryan who tinkered with anything that moved and loved games, like Red Rover and Capture the Flag. I remember the Ryan that was filled with joy and life. The person I see in front of me is sad, and beaten down. And . . . I would take care of you. I'd help you with your dream, too. I'd see you, for who you really are.

RYAN: Nothing would change. You work here, I work here. If we quit, we're unemployed, we'd have to move, the divorce would cost money, we'd go bankrupt. We'd be homeless, for God's sake.

JESSICA: We'd figure it out.

RYAN: Dammit, Jessica, not everything in life can be solved with a little naiveté and hope!

JESSICA: I believe that it can!

RYAN: You're a fool.

JESSICA: Come away with me.

RYAN: Stop.

JESSICA: I'm serious. We could leave tonight, tomorrow. You write Nancy a letter, and we leave. I have enough saved up for us to move to the city and get a god-awful apartment, but it could be something. I'll get another job as an exec, I'm sure of it! And then, then we can open your store together. Get married, have a couple of kids, the whole white picket fence package. You could finally play catch with the son you've always wanted.

A beat. Jessica has painted a beautiful picture of the life Ryan has, admittedly, always wanted. She crosses to him, takes his hands.

JESSICA: We could be a real family, have a real life. You could stop living this boring, exhausting gray one. I loved you then and I would love you just as much now. And I think . . . I think part of you feels the same way, too.

Slowly, hesitantly, she reaches up and cups his face in her hands. She carefully and deliberately kisses him. He kisses back softly, for a brief moment, then puts his hands about her wrists and pulls them gently from his face, breaking their embrace.

RYAN: I know you won't believe it, and I know you'd like to think that every love story ends with riding off into the sunset, but those are children's tales. Love is not child's play, Jessica. Neither is real life. I loved you then, that's true, and a part of me always will. But 'first love', it's not always the same as 'true love' or 'forever love'. Nancy and I promised each other a forever. We've been with each other for birthdays, Christmases, Thanksgivings with her family and mine. We've had fights; we've seen each other cry. We've done normal couple things – dinners and

movies and love making and doing nothing at all. We've built a life. And it's not perfect. But it's ours. This is my boring, exhausting, gray life. It's not perfect, but it's mine. And I'm not going to trade something that I've grown to love for something I'm not sure I can love forever.

Jessica nods, and pulls away completely. She's crying, a little.

JESSICA: I really thought-

RYAN: I know.

JESSICA: You must think I'm such an idiot.

RYAN: No, I really don't. I think you're brave, Jes, you always were.

JESSICA: Yeah, so brave. Brave enough to think I could change your mind.

She laughs a sad little laugh. Ryan crosses to her, and kisses her forehead.

RYAN: Stay, and finish your coffee?

JESSICA: No, I better not. I better not. Consider this my official resignation, I guess?

RYAN: After one day? They're going to think I scared you away.

JESSICA: They're lucky I didn't scare *you* away. *(A beat)* Take care of yourself, Ryan. And tell Nancy you love her when you get home, alright?

RYAN: Yeah. Yeah, I will, Jes. Take care.

Jessica turns to leave, but stops herself short of the door.

JESSICA: One more thing. In a month or so, you're going to get a letter from me. An invitation, to a party of sorts. Don't be afraid to open it, okay? You should open it.

RYAN: *(Bewildered, yet compliant)* I will.

JESSICA: *(Smiling, sadly)* Goodbye, Ryan.

She shares a final, lingering look with him, and then hums the Camp Kickapoo song as she exits. Ryan watches her go, even after she's left. After a beat of this, he turns and speaks to us:

RYAN: I went home that night and kissed my wife. I told her I loved her, but I didn't tell her about Jessica. It wasn't something she needed to know. I didn't think about it again until I got Jessica's letter. It was a cordial invitation to the funeral of Ms. Jessica Monroe. Turns out that by the time Jessica ran into me, she was already dying, and she knew it. Cancer, eating away at her brain. She knew the whole time, and never said a word. I was almost angry, until another piece of paper fell out.

Ryan takes the letter from his pocket, begins to read.

RYAN: 'Dear Ryan: If you're reading this, then, well, you know what that means. I'm sorry I didn't tell you, but I didn't want you to feel compelled to take pity on the poor dying girl. I wanted – I needed – to know if you loved me back, for real. I got my answer, and that's okay. I will always keep our time together close to my heart, and I'll never forget-

Seamlessly, Jessica's voice takes over, as she steps out from behind Ryan to read the letter to him as he holds it in front of him.

JESSICA: -the times we kissed and the way you always made me laugh. First loves are a powerful thing, you understand. They stay with you. You were a good friend to me, right to the very end. Even after fifteen years you wouldn't let me make an impulsive decision that wasn't right for me, and I thank you for that. Ryan, please know that I-

RYAN: -I will always love you, and that –

JESSICA: -once I'm gone, you should forget any of this ever happened. All those things that I said and did, they were the ravings of a sick woman, living out her last romantic fantasy. But, I'm glad my last romantic fantasy was with you. Even if fantasy is all it will ever be. But before I go, promise me one thing.

RYAN: Buy your toy shop. Convince Nancy to help you find a way to do it, now. Co-invest, or something, I don't care, just-

JESSICA: -do it. Not for me. God no, not for me. For you. For your dad, and the Lincoln Logs, and the children you may or may not ever have. Just do it for you, Ryan. Be a kid again.

RYAN & JESSICA: Love always, Jessica.'

Ryan smiles at the letter, and slowly folds it back up. After a beat, he addresses the audience a final time:

RYAN: My life is filled with routine. Every morning, I get up, I cook breakfast, and my wife Nancy and I? We open our toy store. And it will be this way for years and years. *(A triumphant, beatific beat)* Thanks to her.

He smiles, and Jessica, his childhood love, smiles too.

END OF PLAY.